Week 20

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 5 · LESSON 4

Apostles

BIG IDEA

The apostles saw Jesus live, die and rise, and they kept preaching even when it cost them their lives. People don't die for what they know is a lie, so their witness is strong evidence and a call for students to live their faith beyond youth group.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. Faith feels easy at camp or youth group among other Christians; the real test is following Jesus around everyone else once Monday comes.
2. Little is known of the apostles' lives, but many died and all were willing to die for their message; in Acts 4:20 Peter and John say they can't stop speaking of what they saw and heard.
3. The apostles weren't liars: no one gives their life for something they know is made up. Their boldness shows the power of the Holy Spirit and the gospel.
4. Students will say others die for their beliefs too. The difference: the apostles were eyewitnesses who lived with Jesus and saw Him die and rise, not people repeating what was handed down.
5. Use the discussion questions on the apostles' conviction and fate; accounts of how each died vary and online sources aren't always accurate, but their suffering is certain.
6. Close the unit by looking back: miracles happen, the resurrection is the greatest, it confirms Jesus is God, and those who saw it died for it. Now how will students live?

SCRIPTURE IN THE VIDEO Acts 4:20

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. Is my faith as bold outside church as it is among other believers?
2. Where do I need courage to speak about what I've seen God do?
3. How does the apostles' witness strengthen my own confidence in the resurrection?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. How would you describe the conviction the apostles had for their message?
2. Why does it matter that the apostles were eyewitnesses and not just sincere believers?
3. If you saw something and knew it was true, how far would you go to make sure people heard it?
4. Why is following Jesus easier at youth group or camp than at school, and what makes the difference?
5. What does the apostles' courage mean for how you'll live out your faith this week?

Summary and transcript of the Week 20 Leader Video, for this church's Awana® leaders: internal ministry use only, not for redistribution. Awana® and Journey: Advocates® and the Journey mark are trademarks of Awana Clubs International, used here by a member church; this handout is not affiliated with or endorsed by Awana. The transcript is of the Leader Video, lightly edited for reading.

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Coming down from the mountaintop

0:05 If you've been leading youth for any time, you've probably done a retreat. And if you've been leading youth for any time and you've done a retreat, then you've probably had that mountaintop experience where students you didn't at all expect would meet Jesus in that space did. It was awesome, and you loved every minute of it, right? And then you come down from the mountain, so to speak. Then Monday comes, and all of a sudden it starts to feel like we're right back to where we were.

0:39 I think a lot of that is because it's super cool to love Jesus when we're at camp and everybody around us loves Jesus. It's super cool to talk about discipleship and spiritual formation, and talking about Jesus to the lost, and going out and being a witness for Christ in a world that desperately needs to hear the gospel. All of that is super cool to talk about, and it's exciting when we're in this little pressure cooker of Christians.

1:11 And so often we go out, and we send our students out, and they come back the same way they were, and we're left saying, what the heck happened? It's because Christianity is not super cool out there. It may be super cool in your youth group — which is awesome — but it's not necessarily super cool out there. It's easy to be a Christian inside the context of a youth group, right? It's easy to be a Christian when we're up at camp. It's easy to be a Christian around other Christians. What happens when we need to be a follower of Jesus around everyone else? Not so easy.

The lives of the apostles

1:45 One thing your students are going to get a chance to learn this week is about the lives of the apostles. Now, we don't know a whole lot about the lives of the apostles, but what we do know is that many of them gave, and all of them were willing to give, their lives for the message that they preached. I love what Peter and John say in Acts 4:20, that we can do nothing but speak of the things that we have seen and heard. Even in the face of persecution, where they're being told, don't speak about Jesus anymore, because if you do there are going to be serious consequences. Guess what? They said, no, we're not going to do it. I'm still going to talk about Jesus. You can't stop us, and there's nothing you can do to us to stop us. That's awesome.

2:35 Several times I've prayed, man, God, can I just have that kind of boldness? And yes, I've done the whole thing with my students where I've asked them, if someone held a gun to your head and told you to denounce Jesus, would you? That may be becoming more of a reality in our world now more than ever. But the bottom line is that we want our students to see the power of the Holy Spirit in our lives and the power of the gospel, and how it ought to compel us to

move into spaces where the gospel needs us most, despite the fear, despite the difficulty. That really becomes the focus this week as you get into some things.

3:17 We want students to know that the apostles were not liars — that despite what some people say, they didn't make this stuff up. Why would you give your life over for something you know is completely a lie? That doesn't quite work. And they were willing to die for this belief. That's a profound reality for our students to get after, and it should be a very transformative experience for them.

Others die for their beliefs

3:43 I know what many students are probably going to say to you, and you're probably going to hear this: others have died for their belief. Especially in our world, we hear about it all the time, especially with terrorism — others die for their belief. What makes the apostles so much different, right? They're fervent too. They think what they believe is right. So how come the apostles are different? Yes, that's absolutely true. But here's the difference, and this is something you're going to hear Sean say; I'm just going to echo it. If I died for my faith and I proclaimed it to be true, that's just because I think it's true. It doesn't necessarily make it true. It's because it's been passed down to me, and I think I've got it all figured out, I think I've got it all right, and I'm going to believe that I do.

Eyewitnesses, not just believers

4:27 But the difference is that the apostles saw and were eyewitnesses to Jesus. That's why they're apostles: they actually lived with Jesus, walked with Jesus, saw him die, saw him resurrect, were given the instructions, and they died as a result of that belief. It's a direct correlation, right?

4:52 So you've got this piece to it: here is Jesus, this counter-cultural public figure, an icon, a religious type of person who is spreading news that is totally contrary to what the mainline beliefs were, whether you were Jewish or Roman. So there was fear, there was animosity, there was, who is this guy? What is he doing? What's going on? Then once he was gone, it was like, whew, he's out, we're done. Let's move on.

5:28 And then all of a sudden these apostles, these people who were with Jesus, start carrying this on. Now imagine for a moment that this is not true, and you're one of the apostles, and you get told: shut it down, or you're going to lose your life. What do you pick? I'm not going to carry this lie. There's nothing in it for me. What do I care? You're not going to die for something you know is a lie. But they so believed it — the resurrection changed them so much — that they were willing to have their lives put to an end, in some horrific ways, mind you. Now, it doesn't prove anything beyond the shadow of a doubt, but it does show that the apostles were not lying.

Small group discussion questions

6:06 So in your small group time, focus in on the student discussion questions. Specifically: how would you describe the conviction the apostles had for their message? Dive into that a little bit deeper. How would you describe their conviction? And do you agree with their conviction? Ask your students honestly: did these apostles seem absolutely out of their minds? Why would you do this? Or is there something more going on here?

6:33 Help them make the connection of what it would be like if you were there. Try to connect them to it and bridge the gap between then and now, and bring your students into that space now. Find an example, find something that will help them understand: if you absolutely saw something and you knew it to be true, how far would you go to make sure that truth came out? How far would you go? We see it all the time in movies and media and music and other places, where we want the truth to come out and we're willing to go to great lengths to make sure of that. So how far would they go?

7:11 The third one is, what fate did the apostles meet due to their relentless devotion to spreading the gospel? Have them look back into that. Now, there is some wide disagreement on the exact fate of some of them, and you can look into that. Be careful what you find if you go looking on the internet. Not all of it is 100% accurate. There are some things that are church tradition, not necessarily historically accurate, but it still makes the point that they did suffer and die as a result. How they suffered and died is a little bit up for debate, but we know that they did, for sure.

7:47 And lastly, what does the apostles' fate mean for the faith of your students? This is going to get into the nitty-gritty of things, because this seems so distant, right? This seems so far off, something so old that it doesn't really matter anymore. It doesn't concern me. I'm in my nice, comfy whatever. It's fine. Bring it. What does it mean for them? Have them think that through and talk it through specifically. Make them dig deep. If they give an answer that leaves you asking, why? — ask them to go a little bit deeper and really pull out of them what it would mean. And what does it now mean moving forward? How are they going to live differently? How are they going to act differently, knowing this information?

Looking back over the unit

8:33 Then take some time and look back at what you've looked at over the last couple of weeks. You've got miracles. A miracle is verifiable. It's testable. We know that miracles exist. We see the greatest miracle in the history of the world in the resurrection of Jesus. That resurrection miracle solidifies the claim that Jesus is God, the Creator of all. And that message of the gospel, and who Jesus is, and what was going on in the world, was so compelling, so powerful, so life-changing that the apostles who saw it, witnessed it and lived it died because of it. That's powerful, powerful testimony.

9:19 Have your students look back on the whole blanket of concepts that we've just laid out over the last four weeks. Have them take a hard look at their faith and say, now how do I move with

all this knowledge? I can't stay here. I can't just know this and move on. Now that I know all of this, what does it look like for me moving forward in my walk with Christ?